

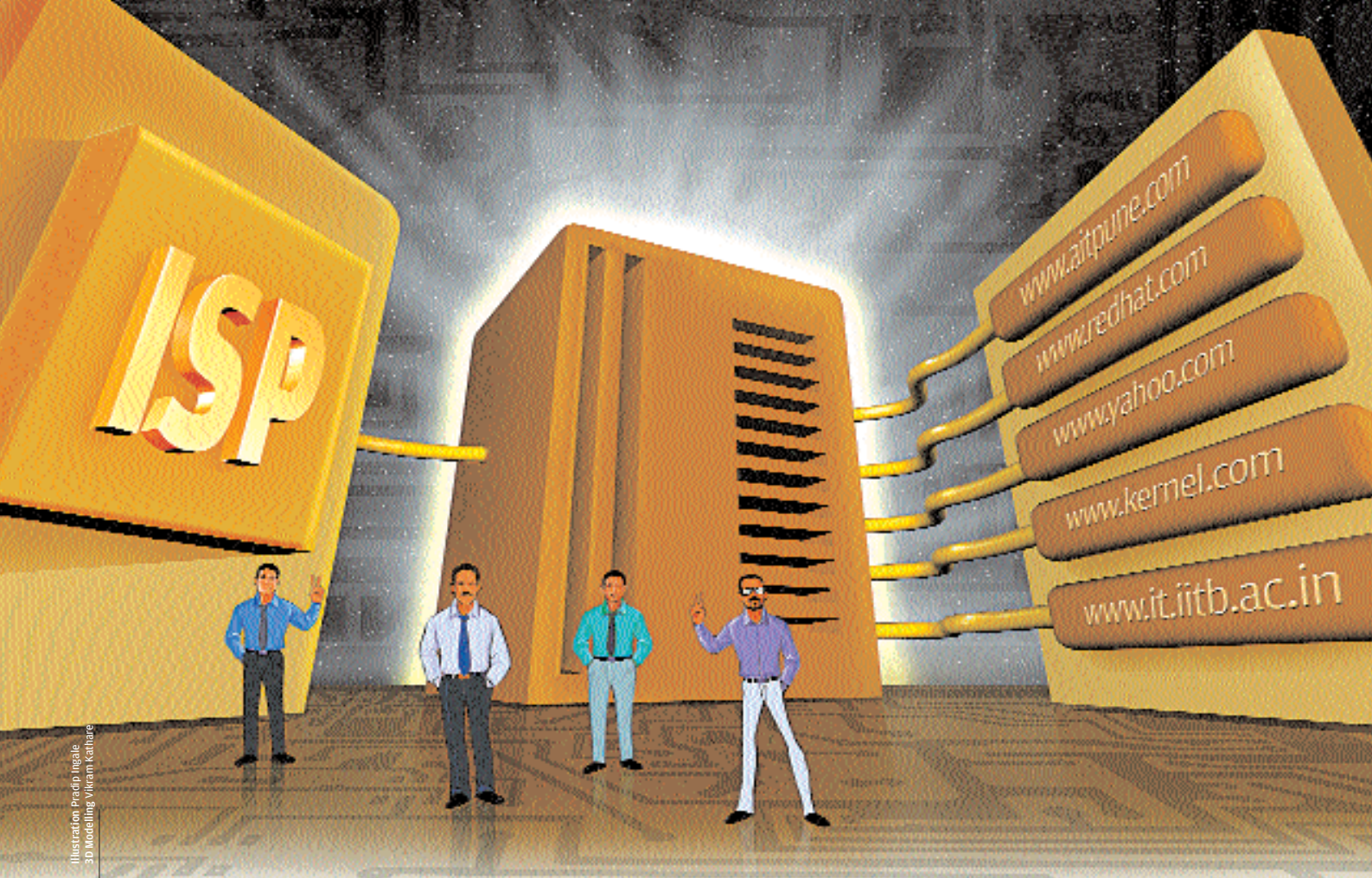


Illustration: Pradipt Ingale
3D Modelling: Vikram Kathare

Lords Of The Code

A project on Open Source technology brings prestige and pelf to graduates of the Army Institute of Technology at Pune

Renuka Rane

Amit Yadav, Narender Kumar, Nishant Kumar and Pranay Pramod are jubilant—and with good reason. Just last month, this winning foursome walked away with the top honours—Rs 2 lakh—for their project on Virtual Private Server (VPS) 2.6.5-1.358 which they entered in the Red Hat Scholarship programme 2004-05. Their joint efforts made it possible to host several Web sites simultaneously on a single PC using distinct VPSes that run independently.

How It All Started

Yadav, the two Kumars, and Pramod are children of serving Army personnel. Ever since joining the AIT in 2001, they have been the thickest of pals.

During their second year of engineering, they were introduced to the philosophy of Open Source by a senior, who later joined Red Hat. This cursory introduction sufficed to arouse their interest in the concept and its possibilities. When the first Red Hat Scholarship was announced last year, they decided to compete for it.

What's Red Hat And Open Source?

As most of you may be aware, software is compiled source code. Open Source, as the name suggests, means the code is protected by a special license, but one that allows everyone to access it. On the other hand, in the case of proprietary software such as Windows, only programmers employed with the company can write or alter the code.

While both Open Source and proprietary software have their positives and negatives, the major negative of proprietary software is that shortcomings and remedies are never known to the real users—the public at large.

With Open Source, on the other hand, users can—often collaboratively—see the code, change it and fix problems. Open Source is a philosophy based on collaboration, community and collective ownership of intellectual property. Open Source allows the best technology to win in an open, competitive environment.

What's needed for one to be able to work with the Open Source code is a knowledge of the programming language, and, how the code interacts with the operating system (OS)—entailing some knowledge of the working of the OS.